TWENTY-THIRD SUNDAY AFTER PENTECOST

Octava post Sanctum Cyprianum.

The Würzburg Capitulary, which omits two Gospel lessons between the Third and the Sixth Sunday "*post Sanctum Cyprianum,*" reckons only six weeks after the feast of the Bishop of Carthage who was associated at Rome with the veneration that the faithful paid to Pope Cornelius (251-2). The list, therefore, is obviously defective and inexact.

At length we hear the divine answer to our humble supplications of last Sunday: "The Lord saith: I think thoughts of peace and not of affliction; you shall call upon me and I will hear you;" indeed, I will send to you a redeemer, who will bring you back from captivity to the bosom of his holy Church. In this manner the sacred Liturgy prepares the minds of the faithful for the celebration of Advent; so that the coming of the incarnate Word may find all hearts ready to receive his grace.

The Introit is derived from Jeremias, but with certain textual alterations (xxix, 11, 12, 14). The Lord, even when he punishes, does not forget his mercy, indeed he chastises because he loves, according to those words in the Apocalypse: *Ego quos amo, arguo et castigo.* Therefore, at the very moment when by the mouth of Jeremias, the Prophet of disasters and lamentations, God announced to the people of Israel the coming destruction of their kingdom and their exile in Babylon, he alleviated the severity of that chastisement by the promise of their future return to their own land and of the restoration of the kingdom of David.

The Collect implores pardon for the sins committed by the Christian community through human weakness. The prayer is universal, because it concerns the personal and general condition of the whole race of Adam. Humility, then, is necessary to all, and no one can assume a deceptive puritanical attitude like that of the haughty Pharisee. "Lord, if it is in the nature of man to sin and to be defiled by the mud of this world, let it also be in the nature of thy ineffable compassion to wash away in thy sacred blood the stains of his guilty conscience."

In to-day's Lesson from the Epistle to the Philippians (iii, 17-21; iv, 1-3) St Paul laments over the lot of those unhappy "enemies of the cross of Christ," who have made sensuality and gluttony their God, and whose end is eternal damnation. Christian life, on the other hand, has a wholly supernatural ideal, which through its union with, and participation in, the sufferings of Jesus, is a prelude to the day when the Lord

will raise up our mortal bodies and fill them with the glory of his transfigured humanity. The Apostle concludes his letter with special exhortations to concord and mutual charity, particularly among the deaconesses and the members of the ecclesiastical body at Philippi.

The Gradual is taken from Psalm xliii, and is well adapted to the celebration of the victories of the martyrs: "Thou hast delivered us, O Lord, from them that afflict us: and hast put them to shame that hate us. In God we will glory all the day: and in thy name we will give praise for ever." Those that afflict the faithful are the devils and their allies here on earth—that is, the wicked. God has delivered the martyrs from the violence of their hatred and has covered their persecutors with shame. For when tyrants condemned those heroic confessors of the faith to the stake and the rack, their hatred did not rage so much against their mortal bodies as against their souls, which they desired to corrupt by sin.

In what way did God triumph in his martyrs? He abandoned the mutilated body to the tyrant and bore the soul of the victor in safety to heaven. The persecutor saw himself deprived all at once of his prey and felt the full disgrace of defeat. He had thought to conquer, but the martyr died rather than yield, and with the glory of his victory he often associated the witnesses of his combat, who, seeing the constancy of the Christian heroes in the midst of their sufferings, were themselves converted to the Faith. Thus the blood of the martyrs becomes fertile seed, bringing forth new Christians, whilst the efforts of the persecutor only increase the shame and disaster of his failure.

The alleluiatic verse comes from Psalm cxxix: "Out of the depths I have cried to thee, O Lord." O thou who are drawn to us the more powerfully, according as our misery is greater, do thou raise upon this very misery the magnificent trophy of thy mercies. Transform the good thief into a confessor of thy divinity; change the persecutor into an apostle, make of a libertine an Augustine, greatest of teachers, so that the deeper the abyss which separated all those from thy grace, the grander may be the triumph of thy mercy, which has been able to fill it with love, and to build on such a foundation as our human misery and thy divine greatness a lasting memorial of thy pity.

The Gospel from St Matthew (ix, 18-26), with the account of the resurrection of the daughter of Jairus and of the healing of the woman who was troubled with an issue of blood, gives a proof of the power of faith to which God has promised to grant all things. The faith of the sick woman is vigorous, but at the same time so humble that she, poor and forlorn, does not even dare to speak to Jesus to ask him

to heal her. The faith of the ruler of the Synagogue, on the other hand, is also strong, but for various reasons it cannot be compared to that of the poor sick woman; his rank, his riches, the music, the noise made by the relations and friends who were surrounding the bed, the scornful laughter of the sceptics, all these things were very unfavourable for the working of a miracle, so our Lord first of all sent away the crowd and then, being left alone with the parents of the child, he called her back to life. By this we see what obstacles the luxury and vanity of the world can put in the way of grace; whereas the poor and the humble are ready at any time, even on the highway, like the sick woman, to receive the gifts of God.

The Offertory verse is the same as the alleluiatic verse. Also the gifts which we offer to God must be accompanied by the incense of humility. We bring to God *de suis donis ac datis*, and nothing really of our own. Besides, it is not God who has need of our gifts and of our worship, but we who in the depth of our misery have an immense need of him.

In the Secret we say to God that we offer up to him the sacrifice of praise—the perfect praise which the Incarnate Word alone can offer to the Father—in order to obtain the grace of being ever more and more devoted to the service of his altar. May he who has granted to his humble servants so powerful a means of obtaining grace at its very source, deign also to grant us that which he has already promised us. The expression in the prayer *pro nostrae servitutis augmento* is very significant. It points to an intensification of the spirit of our liturgical and sacerdotal vocation, for the *servitus* here stands for what the Greeks mean by λειτουργίας,[1] that is, the *servitium sanctum*, the ministry of the altar.

The Communion is drawn from St Mark (xi, 24), but it must be out of its proper place. The Gregorian Antiphonary has the first verse of Psalm cxxix: "Amen, I say to you, whatsoever you ask when you pray, believe that you shall receive and it shall be done unto you."

St Augustine has explained very clearly the conditions necessary for obtaining that which we, as Christians, pray for. Or rather we may say that prayer always attains its primary end, since the supreme desire of our hearts is happiness, and God grants to us this true and complete happiness by placing each one of us in the circumstances in which we can most easily attain it. These circumstances vary according to our subjective dispositions, and this explains the different ways in which God treats different souls. Thus he leads one to heaven by means of wealth, another through

[1] Luke i, 23.

poverty; to one he gives vigorous health, another he paralyses with illness; each receives that which is most profitable to him for attaining eternal life.

The Post-Communion is of a general character. "We beseech thee, almighty God, that thou suffer us not to yield to human perils whom thou hast gladdened by giving us a share in things divine." We do not ask here that God should withdraw us from the battle—for that would mean the loss of virtue and merit, since St James declares that man to be blessed who sustains the trial—but we pray him by the merits of the holy Sacrifice so to strengthen us with his grace that the devil may have no part in us according as Christ himself said before his passion: *Venit princeps mundi hujus et in me non habet quidquam.*

How much easier it is to save one's soul in the midst of poverty and in a humble and obscure condition of life! Not that riches or worldly position are in themselves blameworthy; but very often to these advantages are joined certain dispositions of one's mind and one's surroundings which render the service of God very difficult to carry out. Such persons begin by excessive pre-occupation concerning their material possessions, and end by losing altogether the supernatural sense of Christian life and holy mortification, becoming at last *inimicos crucis Christi,* as St Paul sadly remarks.

TWENTY-FOURTH SUNDAY AFTER PENTECOST

This is the last of the summer cycle, and is, as it were, a prelude to the holy season of Advent. The Collect, which in enigmatical phrase promises us the *remedia majora,* and the Gospel Lesson, describing the second coming of the Son of God, prepare our souls for the great event which is about to be celebrated. In five weeks more, the Word of God, clothed in human flesh, will make his first entrance into the world, and, as the Apostle says in the Epistle to the Colossians which is read to-day, God himself will then lead us definitely into the kingdom of love, founded by his beloved and only-begotten Son.

The Gregorian Antiphonary assigns only twenty-four Sundays to the period between Pentecost and Advent. As, however, the actual duration of this cycle depends on the date of Easter, and if because of a very early Septuagesima the Offices of some of the Sundays after the Epiphany have to be omitted, these Collects and Lessons are restored after the Twenty-third Sunday after Pentecost. This is so arranged that both the antiphonic and the responsorial chants of this last Sunday of the autumn cycle are regularly